



THE NEXTUP DIY CREDIT GUIDE

Fix Your Own Credit

Without the Myths

An honest, step-by-step walkthrough of the dispute process —
what the law actually gives you, what actually works,
and the eight letters you need to do it yourself.

NextUP Enterprise

Board Certified Credit Consultants
150+ clients helped

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Contents

Everything in this guide, in the order you should use it.

01 Read This First	4
02 How You Got Here Isn't the Point	6
03 Get All Three Reports the Right Way	8
04 Read the Report Like an Auditor	10
05 What the Law Actually Gives You	12
06 The Deletion Test	14
07 Build Your File Before You Send Anything	16
08 Round One — Disputing With the Bureaus	17
09 When They Say "Verified"	19
10 Going Straight to the Source	20
11 Collections and Debt Validation	21
12 Timelines, Medical Debt, and Public Records	23
13 Goodwill Requests	25
14 Myths That Will Cost You Months	26
15 Build While You Repair	28
16 Your 90-Day Plan	30
17 When to Stop Doing This Yourself	32
Letter Templates	34
Letter 1 — Personal Information Correction	35

Letter 2 — Dispute of Inaccurate Information 37

Letter 3 — Request for Method of Verification 39

Letter 4 — Direct Dispute to the Furnisher 41

Letter 5 — Debt Validation — Within 30 Days 43

Letter 6 — Dispute of a Reported Collection 45

Letter 7 — Goodwill Adjustment Request 47

Letter 8 — Removal of Obsolete Information 49

You Don't Have to Do This Alone 51



01

Read This First

There is a version of this guide I could have written that would have sold you a lot harder. It would have told you that every negative item on your credit report can be deleted, that the bureaus are legally required to remove anything you challenge, and that thirty days from now you would be a different person financially.

That guide sells well. It also gets people into trouble, and it is the reason so many of the people who come to us have already spent money on a “credit repair kit” and gotten nowhere.

So here is the honest version instead.

The credit reporting system makes mistakes constantly. Real, documented, provable mistakes — wrong balances, accounts that belong to someone else, dates that were quietly changed, debts that should have aged off years ago, collections reported by companies that cannot produce a single piece of paper connecting them to you. The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau receives more complaints about credit reporting than about any other financial product in the country, by a wide margin. That is not a conspiracy theory. That is the system running at scale and dropping things.

The law gives you specific, enforceable tools to make them fix those mistakes. This guide teaches you those tools and how to use them properly.

What it will not do is teach you to challenge accurate information by pretending you do not recognize it. That approach is everywhere online, it is what most of the cheap kits sell, and it does three things to you: it gets your disputes flagged as frivolous and dismissed under the law, it wastes months you cannot get back, and depending on how it is done, it can cross into misrepresentation. If an account is genuinely yours, genuinely late, and genuinely being reported correctly, no letter is going to remove it. Time and rebuilding will.

The core idea in one sentence: you are not asking the bureaus for a favor — you are holding them to an accuracy standard the law already requires of them, and documenting it when they fall short.

Everything after this page assumes you are willing to do that honestly. If you are, this works. We have watched it work across more than a hundred and fifty client files.

Who put this together

NextUP Enterprise is a credit repair and credit building firm run by Board Certified Credit Consultants. We are not a national call center, and we did not fall into this line of work. It grew out of watching how much of this system is built to be difficult to navigate, and how much changes for somebody once they get through it.

More than a hundred and fifty clients later, the approach has not changed: real plans, real work, honest answers about what is possible on a given file.

We know what it is like to be on the wrong side of an approval decision — denied, overlooked, and unsure who to ask. That is the whole reason this company exists, and it is why we give this guide away instead of selling it.

How to use this guide

- Read Sections 1 through 6 before you send anything. Most people who fail at this fail because they started writing letters on day one.
- Work through the sections in order. The dispute process is sequential — later steps depend on the paper trail earlier steps create.
- The letter templates start on their own pages toward the back. They are clean and unbranded on purpose so you can copy them straight into a document without editing anything out.
- Use the 90-day plan in Section 16 as your calendar. Credit repair is a scheduling problem more than a writing problem.

Get stuck at any point, hand it to us

If this turns into more than you want to manage, that is not a failure — it is most people. Book a free consultation and we will look at your reports with you, tell you honestly what is workable, and you can decide from there.

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02

How You Got Here Isn't the Point

Almost everyone who sits down with us opens by explaining themselves. The layoff. The hospital stay. The divorce that took eighteen months and drained an account that was supposed to be for something else. The business that almost worked. The card that got handled by somebody who was supposed to be handling it.

You do not owe us that explanation and you do not owe it to a credit bureau either. Your credit report does not record why anything happened. It records what was reported, by whom, and when. That is the entire scope of what you are working with, and it is actually good news — it means the job in front of you is technical, not moral.

What matters is the state of the file right now, which of the items in it can be legitimately challenged, and what you build on top once the challenges are done.

What your score is actually measuring

A credit score is a prediction. It is a number estimating how likely you are to fall ninety days behind on something in the next twenty-four months. It is not a measure of income, character, or how hard you are trying. Five categories drive it:

- Payment history (roughly 35%) — whether you paid on time. Late payments, charge-offs, and collections live here. This is the heaviest category and the slowest to fix.
- Amounts owed (roughly 30%) — mostly your revolving utilization, meaning card balances against card limits. This is the fastest-moving category and the one most people ignore.
- Length of credit history (roughly 15%) — the age of your oldest account and the average age of all of them.
- Credit mix (roughly 10%) — whether you have handled both revolving accounts and installment loans.
- New credit (roughly 10%) — recent applications and newly opened accounts.

Note the split. About sixty-five percent of your score comes from payment history and utilization. Disputing errors works on the first. Section 15 works on the second. Doing only one of them is why people clean up their report and watch their score barely move.

Two things people confuse constantly

The first is the difference between how long something can be reported and how long it can be collected. Those are separate clocks governed by separate laws. A debt can fall off your credit report and still be legally collectible, and a debt can be past your state's statute of limitations and still sit on your report. Do not assume one tells you anything about the other.

The second is that there is no single credit score. Experian, TransUnion, and Equifax each hold a separate file, and lenders run different scoring models against them — the FICO version a mortgage underwriter pulls is not the version your banking app shows you for free. Expect the numbers to disagree. Work on the underlying files and the scores follow.



03

Get All Three Reports the Right Way

You cannot dispute what you have not read, and you cannot read what you have not pulled from the right place. This step takes twenty minutes and roughly a third of people skip it, then dispute from a screenshot of a score app that does not show them account numbers.

Where to get them

AnnualCreditReport.com is the only source authorized by federal law, it is free, and it gives you Experian, TransUnion, and Equifax. It is run by the bureaus themselves under a requirement in the Fair Credit Reporting Act. There is no upsell and no card required. Anything charging you for your own file is selling you something you already have a right to.

Pull all three. Do not pull one and assume the others match — they routinely do not, and the discrepancies between them are frequently your best evidence. An account that two bureaus deleted and the third kept is a much stronger dispute than an account you simply do not like.

Free once a year, or monitored all year

AnnualCreditReport.com is free and it is the right starting point. The limitation is what happens next. This process runs in thirty-five to forty-five day cycles, and at the end of every cycle you need a fresh copy of all three reports to compare against the one you saved. Pulling those one at a time, re-verifying your identity each round, is where a lot of people quietly stop.

That is the reason we point clients toward a three-bureau monitoring service instead. You get all three reports and scores in one place, refreshed on a schedule, with alerts when something on any of the three files changes — which is exactly what you are trying to detect during a dispute cycle. Use whichever service you like. The one we use with clients is below.

Pull all three reports and start monitoring

See all three bureaus side by side, get alerted the moment a tradeline changes, and stop re-pulling reports by hand every cycle. This is the setup the rest of this guide assumes you have.

Get your 3-bureau report · Free annual reports instead

Disclosure: the link above is a referral link. If you sign up through it, NextUP Enterprise may receive a commission at no additional cost to you. You are never required to use it — your free annual reports at

AnnualCreditReport.com will work for everything in this guide, and the second link above goes straight there.

Save each report as a PDF the day you pull it, and name the files with the date. Every dispute you send from here forward is a comparison between the version you have and the version they produce next. Without dated copies you are arguing from memory, and memory loses.

What you are entitled to see

Under Section 609 of the Fair Credit Reporting Act you have the right to all information in your file, the sources of that information, and — on request — a list of everyone who has received your report recently. That is a genuine and useful right.

It is also the single most misrepresented section of the law online. Section 609 does not require a bureau to mail you a signed original contract, and a letter demanding one is not a legal maneuver. It is a myth that has been resold for fifteen years, the bureaus recognize the template on sight, and it will cost you a dispute cycle. There is more on this in Section 14.

Also pull these while you are at it

- Your ChexSystems report, if you have ever had a checking account closed on you. Free at chexsystems.com and it is why some people cannot open a bank account.
- Your LexisNexis consumer file. Free on request, and it is one of the vendors bureaus buy public-record and insurance data from.
- Your specialty reports — the CFPB publishes a list of consumer reporting companies covering rentals, employment screening, and utilities. If you have been denied an apartment, that file matters more than your FICO.

04

Read the Report Like an Auditor

Here is the shift that makes this whole process work. You are not scanning for things you dislike. You are auditing three documents against each other, looking for internal contradictions, and building a list of specific factual defects you can point at.

Put the three reports side by side. Go tradeline by tradeline. For every single account, check every field.

The audit checklist

- Is the account yours? Not “do you remember it” — is it yours. Accounts genuinely appear on the wrong file: similar names, a family member with the same name, a mixed file, identity theft, or a data-entry error at the furnisher.
- Is the balance right? Compare against your own records and against what the other two bureaus show. A collection reporting a balance that has grown without a contractual basis is a defect.
- Is the date of first delinquency right? This is the most important date on the report. It sets the seven-year clock, and moving it forward is illegal.
- Is the date opened right? Is the date of last activity right? Is the date closed right? Cross-check all three bureaus.
- Is the payment history right? Look at the month-by-month grid. A thirty-day late in a month you can prove you paid is a provable defect. So is a grid that shows lates on an account the summary line calls never late.
- Is the status right? Closed accounts reported open. Paid accounts reported with a balance. Accounts included in a bankruptcy still showing as owing. Settled accounts reported as charged off.
- Is the account listed twice? A charged-off account and the collection agency that bought it both reporting a balance is double-counting the same debt.
- Is the credit limit reported? A card with no limit shown can be scored against your high balance instead, which quietly wrecks your utilization.
- Is it past the reporting period? Section 12 covers the timelines.
- Do the three bureaus agree? Every place they disagree, at least one of them is wrong by definition.

Personal information counts too

Check the names, addresses, dates of birth, and employers listed on each file. Old addresses you never lived at and name variants that are not yours are how files get mixed in the first place. Correcting them is quick, low-risk, and worth doing before anything else. Letter 1 handles it.

Build the list

By the end of this you should have a written list where every row reads: bureau, creditor name, account number, and the specific field that is wrong. Not “Capital One — I do not like this one.” Instead: “TransUnion — Capital One •6231 — reports a balance of \$1,240; Experian and Equifax both report \$0; account was paid in full 03/2024, confirmation attached.”

That second version is a dispute that gets resolved. The first version is a dispute that gets a form letter.

Where the errors actually hide

If you want one shortcut for finding defects fast, it is this: look for disagreement. Line the three reports up and scan across, not down. Any field where Experian, TransUnion, and Equifax do not match is a field at least one of them is reporting wrong, and you do not have to prove which — you just have to point at the conflict. Balances, dates of first delinquency, account status, and credit limits are where the mismatches cluster.

The second shortcut is date math. Take the date of first delinquency on every derogatory account and add seven years and 180 days. Anything past that should already be gone. Furnishers re-date accounts more often than most people would believe, and it is the cleanest dispute in this entire guide when you catch one.

Watch your reports change in real time

Side-by-side three-bureau views make mismatched fields obvious, and change alerts tell you the moment a bureau updates or deletes something — so you are working from what your file says today, not from a report you pulled six weeks ago.

Compare all three bureaus

Not sure what you're looking at?

Send us your three reports and we will do this audit for you at no charge on a consultation call. Twenty years of collective pattern recognition beats a checklist — we spot things people miss on their own file every single week.

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05

What the Law Actually Gives You

You do not need to be a lawyer for this, but you do need to know which four tools exist, because each one does a different job and using the wrong one is why most self-directed attempts stall.

Tool 1 — The bureau dispute (FCRA § 611)

When you tell a credit bureau an item in your file is inaccurate or incomplete, it must conduct a reasonable reinvestigation free of charge and complete it within thirty days. That extends to forty-five days if you supply additional information during the window. The bureau has five business days to forward your dispute to the company that furnished the information, and it must give you the results within five business days of finishing.

Here is the sentence that matters most: if the information is found to be inaccurate, incomplete, or cannot be verified, it must be deleted or corrected. “Cannot be verified” is real leverage — but it means the furnisher failed to confirm it, not that you disagree with it.

The catch: Section 611 also lets a bureau dismiss a dispute it reasonably determines to be frivolous or irrelevant, and it must tell you it did so within five business days. Mass-produced letters with no specific factual claim get dismissed under this provision constantly. Specificity is not a stylistic preference here. It is the thing that keeps your dispute alive.

Tool 2 — The method of verification request (FCRA § 611(a)(7))

After a reinvestigation, you can ask the bureau to describe the procedure it used to determine the accuracy of the item, including the name, address, and — if reasonably available — the phone number of the furnisher it contacted. The bureau has fifteen days from your request to respond.

Be clear about what this is. It is a transparency right, not a deletion trigger. Most of the time you will get a description of the process and the furnisher's contact information. That is still worth having, because it tells you exactly who to aim Tool 3 at, and because a bureau that cannot describe how it verified something has a documented problem.

Tool 3 — The direct dispute with the furnisher (FCRA § 623(a)(8))

You may dispute directly with the company reporting the information rather than going through a bureau. The furnisher must investigate, review the information you provide, and respond within thirty days. If it finds the item inaccurate, it must correct it with every bureau it reported to.

This one is underused and it is often the most effective step in the whole process, because the furnisher is the source. The bureau is a middleman passing a code back and forth. Two requirements: send it to the address the furnisher designates for disputes, and include specific supporting documentation — a direct dispute without it can be treated as frivolous.

Tool 4 — Debt validation with a collector (FDCPA § 1692g)

This one is only for third-party debt collectors, and it is governed by a hard deadline. Within thirty days of a collector's first communication with you, if you dispute the debt in writing, the collector must stop collection activity until it mails you verification of the debt.

Two things people get wrong. First, the thirty-day window runs from the collector's initial contact — not from whenever you discovered the account. Outside that window you can still request verification and you should, but the automatic cease-collection obligation no longer applies the same way. Second, “verification” in practice is a lower bar than the internet claims. Courts have generally accepted an itemized statement from the creditor. A collector is not required to produce a signed original contract, and demanding one as though it were the law is a template the industry recognizes instantly.

Match the tool to the target. Bureaus get § 611 disputes. Original creditors and banks get § 623 direct disputes. Third-party collection agencies get § 1692g validation requests. Sending the wrong instrument to the wrong party is the most common wasted month in this whole process.



06

The Deletion Test

Before you spend a stamp, run every item on your list through four questions. This is the filter that separates people who get results from people who send letters for a year.

Question 1 — Is it accurate?

Every field, not the account overall. An account can be legitimately yours and still be reported wrong in three places. Those three places are your dispute.

Question 2 — Is it complete?

The law requires accuracy and completeness. A tradeline that omits material context — no credit limit shown, a settled account with no settlement notation, a discharged debt with no bankruptcy notation — is incomplete even if nothing on it is technically false. Incompleteness is a legitimate and underused basis for dispute.

Question 3 — Is it still allowed to be there?

Reporting periods are covered in Section 12. Obsolete information must come off regardless of whether it is accurate.

Question 4 — Can the furnisher actually verify it?

This is a real question, not a rhetorical one. Debts get sold two and three times. Companies merge, fold, and lose records. Portfolios get bought with a spreadsheet and nothing behind it. When a collector genuinely cannot verify, the item has to come off. That happens often enough to be worth pursuing — and it is not the same as assuming nobody can verify anything.

If all four come back clean

Then that item stays, and we would rather tell you that now than take six months of your time. An accurately reported, verifiable, in-period late payment or charge-off is going to sit on your file until it ages off. What you do about it is Section 15 — you build enough positive weight around it that it stops mattering to underwriters. That is not a consolation prize. That is how most real approvals actually happen.

One discipline, and it is the one that matters most: never write that you do not recognize an account you do recognize. It is the standard advice in the cheap kits and it is bad advice. Bureaus flag those letters, the disputes get dismissed as frivolous, and you have burned the credibility you need for the real disputes on your list. Dispute what is wrong, precisely, with proof. It works better anyway.



07

Build Your File Before You Send Anything

A dispute is an evidentiary exercise. The person who wins is the one who can produce a dated document. Set this up once and the whole process gets easier.

What to gather

- Dated PDF copies of all three current reports.
- Proof of identity: government ID and a utility bill or bank statement showing your current address. Bureaus reject unsigned or unidentified disputes routinely, and this is the most common reason a dispute dies without ever being read.
- Any documentation supporting a specific claim: payment confirmations, bank statements for the months in question, settlement or paid-in-full letters, bankruptcy discharge paperwork, police reports or FTC identity theft reports, correspondence from the creditor.

How to send

Mail, certified with return receipt. Not the online dispute portal. When you dispute through a bureau's website or app you generally agree to terms that route the dispute through the automated system, and you get no independent proof of what you sent or when they received it. The green card is your timeline. Without it you cannot prove a thirty-day violation ever happened.

Send one letter per bureau. Never send a single letter listing all three. Sign it. Include your full name, current address, date of birth, and Social Security number, and attach the identity documents.

Keep a log

One row per item per bureau: date sent, certified mail number, date received, date of response, outcome, what you sent next. A spreadsheet is fine. If this ever escalates to a CFPB complaint or an attorney, that log is the case.

Do not dispute everything at once. Ten specific, documented disputes get worked. Forty vague ones get pattern-matched to a template and dismissed. Start with your strongest evidence.

08

Round One — Disputing With the Bureaus

Use Letter 2. One per bureau, per the rules in Section 7.

What goes in it

For each item: the creditor name, the account number as it appears on that bureau's report, precisely what is wrong, and what the correct information is. Reference the document you are attaching. Ask for deletion if the item cannot be verified, or correction if it can.

Compare that to what most people send, which is a list of accounts and the phrase “please verify.” The difference in outcome is not close.

The waiting period

Thirty days from receipt, not from mailing. Forty-five if you supply additional information during the window. Add a few days for mail in both directions and put a date on your calendar roughly forty days out. Do not send follow-up letters into the window — it restarts confusion and can get the second letter treated as duplicative.

Reading the response

You will get one of four outcomes per item.

- Deleted. The item is gone from that bureau. Confirm it against a fresh report — do not take the letter's word for it.
- Updated or corrected. Check what actually changed. Sometimes a correction is exactly what you asked for. Sometimes they fixed a trivial field and left the substantive error in place.
- Verified as accurate. Go to Section 9.
- Dismissed as frivolous. Read why. Usually it means the dispute lacked specificity or documentation, or the bureau received near-identical letters. Rewrite it properly and resend — this is fixable.

Pull fresh reports and compare them line by line against your saved copies. Whatever changed is your progress. Whatever did not is your next round.

Do not guess whether anything moved

The single most common mistake at this stage is assuming the results letter is accurate. Pull the actual reports and compare them yourself — deletions get reported that never happened, and corrections get reversed a cycle later.

Pull your updated reports



09

When They Say "Verified"

"Verified as accurate" is where most self-directed attempts end. It should be where yours gets more interesting, because a verification is a factual claim the bureau has now made in writing, and you are entitled to ask how it got there.

Send the method of verification request

Use Letter 3. You are asking for a description of the procedure used to determine accuracy, and the name, address, and phone number of the furnisher contacted. Fifteen days to respond.

Set your expectations correctly. Most responses describe the e-OSCAR system, which is the automated network bureaus use to pass a condensed dispute code to the furnisher and receive a coded confirmation back. That is generally what "verification" consists of. Knowing that is not a magic key — but it tells you two useful things.

- First, you now have the furnisher's dispute address, which is what you need for Section 10.
- Second, if the bureau cannot describe its procedure at all, or names a furnisher that no longer exists, or gives you a response that contradicts what the furnisher tells you directly, you have documented a real problem — and that is the kind of thing that supports a CFPB complaint or gets an attorney's attention.

Then go around them

The productive move after a verification is almost never another bureau letter. It is a direct dispute with the furnisher. The bureau is relaying a code. The furnisher is the one holding the records.

10

Going Straight to the Source

Section 623(a)(8) of the Fair Credit Reporting Act lets you dispute directly with the bank, lender, or creditor reporting the item. Use Letter 4.

Getting it right

- Send it to the address the furnisher designates for disputes. Not the payment address. Most large creditors publish a specific credit reporting dispute address — the method of verification response from Section 9 will usually give it to you, or you can call and ask for the credit bureau disputes department address.
- Include documentation. A direct dispute without supporting information can be treated as frivolous, and this is the most common reason they fail.
- Be specific about the field. “The date of first delinquency is reported as 06/2021; my records and the attached statements show the account first went delinquent 11/2019.”
- Thirty days to investigate and respond. If they find it inaccurate they must correct it with every bureau they reported to — which fixes all three at once.

Special case — mortgages

For anything mortgage-related, you have an additional and stronger tool: a Qualified Written Request under the Real Estate Settlement Procedures Act. A servicer must acknowledge within five business days and substantively respond within thirty. It also has a duty not to report information to a bureau as overdue while a related dispute is being resolved, in certain circumstances. If the disputed item is a mortgage late, use the QWR route — it carries obligations a standard dispute does not.

Special case — auto repossessions

After a repossession, state law under Article 9 of the Uniform Commercial Code generally requires the lender to send you specific notices: a notice of the intended sale and an accounting of any surplus or deficiency. Those requirements are real, they vary by state, and lenders sometimes fail them. Requesting that documentation is a legitimate dispute, and a deficiency balance reported without it is worth challenging.

What is not legitimate is the widely circulated script claiming a repossession balance is automatically zero because of a UCC failure, or that an auto loan is secretly a “credit sale” and therefore unreportable. That language has no legal force, and sending it marks you as working from a template.

11

Collections and Debt Validation

Collection accounts are the most disputable category on most reports, because the collector is usually several steps removed from the original transaction and the records get thinner at every handoff.

Timing determines your leverage

If you are within thirty days of a collector's first communication with you, send Letter 5. This is the real Section 1692g validation request, and it triggers a mandatory pause on collection activity until they mail verification.

If you are outside that window — which is most people, because you often find out about a collection by reading your credit report — send Letter 6 instead. You are still entitled to dispute, and a collector reporting a disputed debt must mark it as disputed, but be honest with yourself that the automatic cease-collection leverage is not there. Letter 6 is written accordingly.

What validation actually requires

Realistically: the amount of the debt, the name of the creditor to whom it is owed, and — under the current federal debt collection rule — an itemization from a reference date showing interest, fees, payments, and credits since. A collector who cannot produce that has a problem. A collector who produces that but not a signed contract does not, whatever the internet says.

The pay-for-delete question

You will see advice to offer payment in exchange for deletion. It happens, some collectors will do it, and if you get an agreement, get it in writing before any money moves — a verbal agreement is worth nothing here.

But know two things. Collectors have agreements with the bureaus that discourage the practice, so many will refuse outright. And paying a collection does not automatically help your score on older scoring models, though newer FICO and VantageScore versions ignore paid collections entirely. Decide based on whether you owe the debt and whether a specific lender is asking you to resolve it, not on a promised score jump.

Statute of limitations — handle carefully

Every state limits how long a creditor can sue you on a debt. The window is commonly somewhere between three and six years on contract debts, but it varies by state and by the type of debt, so look up

your own. Here is the trap: in many states, making a payment or acknowledging the debt in writing can restart that clock and revive a debt that was legally unenforceable.

So on an old debt, know your state's limit before you contact anyone about it, and be careful what you put in writing. This is a genuinely good reason to talk to somebody before you act.



12

Timelines, Medical Debt, and Public Records

How long things can be reported

- Most negative information: seven years.
- Collections and charged-off accounts: seven years plus 180 days from the date of first delinquency on the original account — not from when the collector bought it, and not from when you last paid. Collectors re-date accounts, sometimes carelessly and sometimes not. Check this on every collection you have.
- Chapter 7 bankruptcy: ten years from the filing date. Chapter 13: the bureaus generally remove it at seven years from filing.
- Closed accounts in good standing: typically stay about ten years and help you. Do not try to remove these.
- Hard inquiries: two years on the report, and they stop affecting most scores after twelve months.

Re-aging — moving the date of first delinquency forward so an account stays reportable longer — is prohibited. It is also common enough that you should check the date of first delinquency on every derogatory account against your own records. When you find it, that is one of the cleanest disputes there is.

Judgments and tax liens

The three national bureaus stopped reporting civil judgments and tax liens several years ago after a change in their data standards. If one is still showing on your report, that is a straightforward dispute and it should come off.

Medical debt — the current picture

This area changed a lot and then partly changed back, and there is a great deal of outdated advice circulating. Here is where it actually stands.

- The three bureaus' voluntary policies from 2023 are still in force: paid medical collections are removed regardless of amount, unpaid medical collections under \$500 are excluded, and new medical collections do not appear for a full year from the date of service.

- The federal rule that would have banned medical debt from credit reports nationwide was finalized in January 2025 and then vacated by a federal court in Texas in July 2025. It never took effect. There is currently no federal ban.
- Roughly fifteen states have passed their own restrictions, and they differ from each other. Look up whether yours is one of them — if it is not, the bureau policies above are the whole of your protection.

Practically: check whether the medical collection on your report is under \$500, already paid, or less than a year from the date of service. If any of those apply, it should not be there and that is a clean dispute. And before disputing anything medical, request an itemized bill from the provider — medical billing error rates are high, and a corrected bill at the source solves the credit problem permanently.

One more thing, since it comes up constantly: HIPAA does not prevent a medical debt from being reported or collected. It expressly permits disclosure for payment purposes. Letters demanding a notarized HIPAA release from a collector are a template, and they do not work.



13

Goodwill Requests

There is one category where the right move is not a dispute at all: an isolated late payment on an account that is otherwise clean, with a creditor you still have a relationship with.

The item is accurate. You cannot dispute it away and you should not try. But a creditor can voluntarily ask the bureaus to remove it, and sometimes they will. Use Letter 7.

What makes one work

- The account is current and in good standing now.
- The lateness is genuinely isolated — one or two marks, not a pattern.
- You have a real history with them. Longer is better.
- There was an actual circumstance behind it, and you say what it was plainly. Not a paragraph of adjectives. One or two honest sentences.
- You are asking, not demanding. No statute citations, no threats. The moment it reads like a legal letter it gets routed to a department that has no authority to help you.

Realistic odds

This works maybe one time in four, it depends heavily on the individual creditor, and it costs you a stamp. Send it to the executive customer service address if you can find one rather than general correspondence. If the first attempt gets a form denial, one polite follow-up a couple of months later is reasonable. After that, let it go and let time handle it.

14

Myths That Will Cost You Months

Everything in this list is widely sold and none of it works. Recognizing them protects you from wasting a year and from paying somebody for a kit built entirely out of them.

“Section 609 letters force deletion”

Section 609 is a disclosure right — it says what you can see in your file. It does not require anyone to produce your original signed contract, and it contains no deletion mechanism. This is the most heavily marketed myth in the industry.

“Anything they cannot verify with a signed contract must be deleted”

Verification does not mean producing a wet-ink agreement. It means the furnisher confirmed the information. Building your whole approach around demanding contracts produces a stack of form letters.

“Dispute everything and see what falls off”

This is the frivolous-dispute provision working exactly as designed. Volume disputing gets your file flagged, gets legitimate disputes dismissed alongside the junk, and can get you locked into a suppression process that makes future disputes harder.

“Say you don't recognize the account”

Covered in Section 6 and worth repeating. On an account you do recognize, this is the fastest way to get every dispute you send dismissed — and it is exactly the wrong thing to put in writing to a federal-regulated entity.

“The courthouse letter removes bankruptcies”

The theory is that you write to the clerk of court, get a letter saying they do not verify with credit bureaus, and demand deletion. It circulated for years. It does not work, because bureaus do not call courthouses — they buy public record data from vendors. A clerk confirming they have no direct relationship with Experian proves nothing about where Experian got the record.

“Credit sweeps” and identity-theft claims

Filing a false identity theft report to strip accurate accounts off a file is fraud. It is a federal offense, people have been prosecuted for it, and any company offering you a “sweep” is offering to commit a crime using your name and your signature. Walk away.

“Add yourself as an authorized user on a stranger's account”

Piggybacking on a family member's genuinely shared account is legitimate. Paying a broker to attach you to a stranger's tradeline is not — lenders detect it, scoring models discount it, and it is treated as misrepresentation on an application.

“A new credit file / CPN solves everything”

A CPN sold as a replacement for your Social Security number is either a stolen number, often a child's, or a fabricated one. Using it on a credit application is bank fraud. There is no legal path to a second personal credit file.

The through-line: every one of these tries to make accurate information disappear. The legitimate work is the opposite — finding the genuinely inaccurate information, proving it, and building real credit behind it. It is slower to describe and faster to actually work.



15

Build While You Repair

This is the section people skip, and it is the reason two people can run identical disputes and end up two hundred points apart a year later. Deleting negatives removes drag. It does not create momentum. You have to build the positive side at the same time, and it moves faster than the dispute side does.

Utilization — the fastest lever you have

Roughly thirty percent of your score is amounts owed, and it recalculates every month with no waiting period. Get total revolving utilization under thirty percent, then under ten. Per-card utilization matters too, so a single maxed card drags even if your overall number looks fine.

One tactic almost nobody uses: statement timing. Your issuer reports the balance on your statement closing date, not your due date. Pay the card down before the statement closes and a low balance is what gets reported — even if you use the card heavily all month.

Second tactic: request credit limit increases on cards you already have. Many issuers do soft-pull increases. A higher limit with the same balance is instant utilization improvement and costs you nothing.

Add positive tradelines

- A secured card with a small deposit, used for one recurring small charge and paid in full monthly. Boring on purpose. The point is a clean payment record, not rewards.
- A credit builder loan through a credit union. The payments report as installment history and it diversifies your credit mix.
- Authorized user status on a genuinely shared family account with long history and low utilization.
- Rent and utility reporting services, which add payment history from bills you are already paying. Confirm which bureaus a given service actually reports to before you sign up.

Protect what you have

- Never close your oldest account. Length of history is fifteen percent, and closing your oldest card shortens it permanently.
- Set autopay for at least the minimum on everything. One thirty-day late undoes months of work.
- Space out applications. Each hard inquiry is small, but a cluster in a short window reads as distress to underwriters.

Realistic timeline: utilization changes show up in thirty to sixty days. Deletions show up in one to two dispute cycles. New positive tradelines start carrying weight around six months. Most of our clients see meaningful movement inside forty-five days and finish the main work in four to six months. Anybody promising faster is selling.



16

Your 90-Day Plan

Credit repair is a scheduling problem. Put these on a calendar.

Days 1–10 — Set up

- Pull all three reports. Save dated PDFs of each one — this is your baseline and everything later is measured against it.
- Run the Section 4 audit. Build your written item list.
- Gather ID and supporting documentation. Start your log.
- Fix utilization now — do not wait for disputes. This is the fastest-moving thing you control.

Set up your reports before day one

Everything in this plan is a comparison between the file you saved on day one and the file you pull on day forty-five. Get the baseline right and the rest of the plan runs itself.

Set up 3-bureau access · Free annual reports

Days 10–15 — First mailing

- Letter 1 to each bureau for personal information corrections.
- Letter 2 to each bureau for your strongest documented items. Certified mail, return receipt.
- Letter 4 direct to any furnisher where you have clear proof.
- Open a secured card or credit builder loan if you have fewer than three open positive tradelines.

Days 45–55 — Assess

- Pull fresh reports. Compare line by line to your saved copies — every field, not just whether the account is still listed.
- Log every outcome: deleted, updated, verified, dismissed.
- Letter 3 to any bureau that verified an item without explanation.
- Letter 5 or 6 to any collector, depending on your timing window.

Days 75–90 — Escalate

- Letter 4 direct disputes to the furnishers identified in the method of verification responses.
- Letter 7 goodwill requests for isolated lates on otherwise clean accounts.
- Letter 8 for anything past its reporting period.
- File CFPB complaints on any documented violations — missed thirty-day deadlines, verified items with no method disclosed, corrections that were reversed. Complaints at consumerfinance.gov are free, they go on the record, and they get responses that letters do not.
- Reassess. Some items will need another cycle. Some are done. Some are accurate and staying — shift that energy to Section 15.



17

When to Stop Doing This Yourself

This guide was written to be genuinely usable on your own, and plenty of people will run the whole thing without ever calling us. That is a good outcome, and it is why the letters in the back are unbranded.

But it would be a disservice not to say plainly when handing it off is the better decision.

Call somebody if any of these are true

- You have more than eight or ten derogatory items across three bureaus. The tracking alone becomes a part-time job, and the sequencing matters more than the writing.
- You are on a deadline. Mortgage pre-approval, a lease, a security clearance, a business loan. Mistimed disputes can leave items marked “in dispute,” which many underwriters cannot clear — this is a real and avoidable way to lose a closing.
- You have items that came back verified twice and you do not know what the next move is.
- You are dealing with identity theft, a mixed file, or an old debt near your state's statute of limitations. Each of those has traps that cost real money to step into.
- You have started and stalled before. Most people do. Consistency over four to six months is the actual differentiator, and it is the hardest part to sustain alone.

What we do

We pull and analyze your full profile, identify what is genuinely challengeable, and work all three bureaus and the furnishers every month — tracked, documented, and escalated properly. You get a client portal, so you can see what was sent and what came back instead of wondering. And we work the building side alongside the disputes, because Section 15 is not optional and most services ignore it.

No contracts. Cancel anytime. And we will tell you honestly on the first call if your file does not need us — we have talked people out of hiring us when the right answer was four months of on-time payments and a lower balance.

Book a free consultation

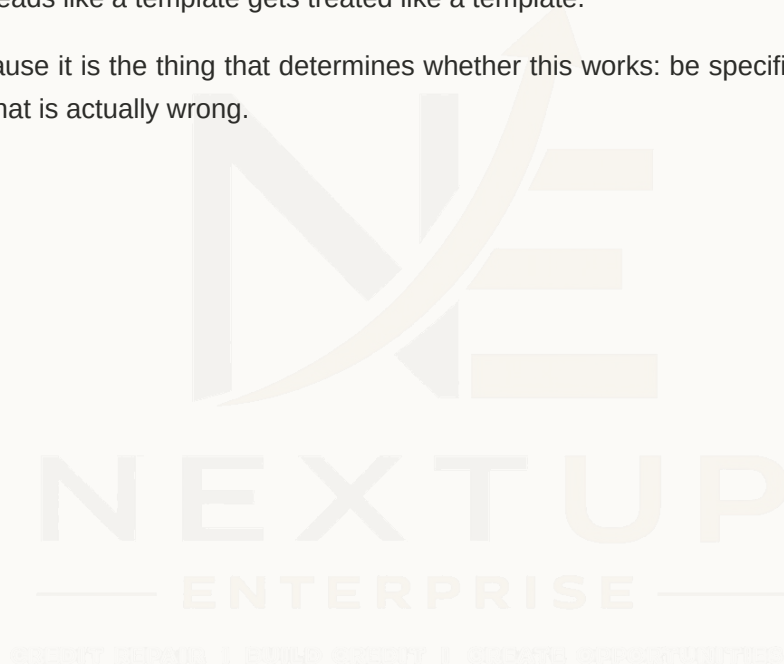
Fifteen minutes, no pressure. Bring your three reports and we will go through them together — you will leave the call knowing what is actually workable on your file whether or not you hire us.

[Book a Free Consultation](#) · [Start the Done-For-You Service](#)

The letters

The eight templates that follow are yours to use. Replace everything in brackets, delete any section that does not apply to your situation, and never send one without changing the specifics to match your actual facts. A letter that reads like a template gets treated like a template.

One last time, because it is the thing that determines whether this works: be specific, attach your proof, and only dispute what is actually wrong.



Letter Templates

Eight letters. Unbranded on purpose — copy them straight out.

The pages that follow are deliberately plain. No logo, no footer, no links — so you can copy a letter into a blank document, fill in your details, and send it without editing anything out. Replace every bracketed field, delete any line that does not apply to your situation, and change the wording so it reads like you. A letter that looks mass-produced gets treated like one.

Send everything certified mail with return receipt requested. Keep a dated copy of every letter you send and every response you get back. That paper trail is the whole game.

Would you rather not write any of these?

This is the part where most people stall out. We draft, send, track, and escalate every letter across all three bureaus and the furnishers, every month, and you watch it happen in your client portal. No contracts, cancel anytime.

[Book a Free Consultation](#) · [Start the Done-For-You Service](#)

— ENTERPRISE —
CREDIT REPAIR · BUILD CREDIT · CREATE OPPORTUNITIES

LETTER TEMPLATE 1

Personal Information Correction

Send to: each credit bureau · Use when: your file lists names, addresses, dates of birth, or employers that are not yours

Do this first. Mixed identifiers are how files get merged with other people's, and correcting them is quick, low-risk, and sometimes clears associated accounts on its own. Attach a copy of your ID and a utility bill or bank statement showing your current address.

[Your full name]

[Your current street address]

[City, State ZIP]

[Date]

[Bureau name]

[Bureau dispute address]

Re: Correction of personal identifying information — [Your full name], SSN ending [last 4]

To whom it may concern:

I have reviewed my consumer file and found personal identifying information that does not belong to me. I am requesting that the following entries be corrected or deleted under the accuracy requirements of the Fair Credit Reporting Act.

Names listed that are not mine:

- [Incorrect name as it appears on the report]

Addresses listed that I have never resided at:

- [Incorrect address as it appears on the report]

Other identifiers that are incorrect:

- [Incorrect date of birth, employer, or phone number as listed]

The only accurate identifying information for my file is the following:

Full legal name: [Your full legal name]

Current address: [Your current address]

Date of birth: [Your date of birth]

Social Security number: [Your SSN]

Enclosed are a copy of my government-issued identification and a [utility bill / bank statement] dated [date] confirming my current address.

Please delete the incorrect entries listed above and send me written confirmation along with an updated copy of my file once the correction is complete.

Sincerely,

[Your signature]

[Your printed name]

Enclosures: copy of ID, proof of address

LETTER TEMPLATE 2

Dispute of Inaccurate Information

Send to: each credit bureau · Use when: a specific field on a specific account is wrong or incomplete

This is your primary tool. Fill in a separate numbered block for each item. Name the exact field that is wrong and what the correct information is — a general request to "verify" an account is what gets dismissed as frivolous. Attach your proof and send certified with return receipt.

[Your full name]

[Your current street address]

[City, State ZIP]

[Date]

[Bureau name]

[Bureau dispute address]

Re: Dispute of inaccurate information — [Your full name], SSN ending [last 4]

To whom it may concern:

I am disputing information in my consumer file that is inaccurate or incomplete. I am submitting this dispute under Section 611 of the Fair Credit Reporting Act, which requires you to conduct a reasonable reinvestigation and to delete or correct any information that is found to be inaccurate, incomplete, or that cannot be verified.

Item 1

- Creditor as reported: [Name exactly as it appears on your report]
- Account number as reported: [Partial account number as shown]
- What is being reported: [State the specific field and the value shown — for example, "a balance of \$1,240" or "a 30-day late payment in March 2023" or "a date of first delinquency of 06/2021"]
- Why it is inaccurate: [State the correct fact — for example, "this account was paid in full on 03/14/2024 and the balance is \$0" or "this payment was made on time; the attached bank statement shows payment posted 03/02/2023"]
- Supporting documentation enclosed: [Describe what you are attaching]
- Requested outcome: [Deletion of this tradeline / correction of the balance to \$0 / removal of the March 2023 late payment notation]

Item 2

- [Repeat the same structure for each additional item.]

Please note that [Bureau name] is reporting this information differently from the other national bureaus. [If applicable: "Experian and Equifax both report this account with a \$0 balance."] I am asking that you resolve this discrepancy.

Enclosed are a copy of my government-issued identification, proof of my current address, and the supporting documentation described above.

Please complete your reinvestigation within thirty days of receipt and send me the results in writing along with an updated copy of my file. If any of the disputed information cannot be verified, please delete it as required.

Sincerely,

[Your signature]

[Your printed name]

[Date of birth] · [Social Security number]

Enclosures: copy of ID, proof of address, supporting documentation

Sent via certified mail, return receipt requested

LETTER TEMPLATE 3

Request for Method of Verification

Send to: the credit bureau that verified an item · Use when: a dispute came back "verified as accurate" with no explanation

You are entitled to a description of the procedure used and the furnisher's contact information, and they have fifteen days to respond. Treat this as an information-gathering step, not a deletion demand — what it usually gets you is the furnisher's dispute address, which is what you need for Letter 4.

[Your full name]

[Your current street address]

[City, State ZIP]

[Date]

[Bureau name]

[Bureau dispute address]

Re: Request for description of reinvestigation procedure — [Your full name], SSN ending [last 4]

To whom it may concern:

On [date you sent your dispute] I disputed the accuracy of information in my file. On [date of their response] you notified me that the following item was verified as accurate:

- Creditor as reported: [Name as it appears]
- Account number as reported: [Partial account number]
- Disputed field: [The specific field you disputed]

Under Section 611(a)(7) of the Fair Credit Reporting Act, I am requesting a description of the procedure used to determine the accuracy and completeness of this information. Specifically, please provide:

- A description of the reinvestigation you conducted, including what was reviewed.
- The business name and address of the furnisher you contacted, and its telephone number if reasonably available.
- The date on which the furnisher was contacted and the date its response was received.
- A description of what the furnisher provided in response.

The statute provides fifteen days from receipt of this request for your response.

I want to be clear about why I am asking. The information I disputed is inaccurate for the reasons I documented, and I provided supporting evidence with my original dispute. If your reinvestigation consisted only of transmitting a summary code to the furnisher and receiving a coded confirmation in return, without any review of the documentation I supplied, I do not believe that satisfies the reasonable reinvestigation

standard the statute requires.

I am also renewing my request that this item be corrected or deleted.

Sincerely,

[Your signature]

[Your printed name]

[Date of birth] · [Social Security number]

Sent via certified mail, return receipt requested

LETTER TEMPLATE 4

Direct Dispute to the Furnisher

Send to: the bank, lender, or original creditor reporting the item · Use when: you have documentation and want to fix the source

Often the most effective letter in this guide, because the furnisher holds the actual records and a correction here propagates to all three bureaus at once. Two requirements: send it to the address the company designates for credit reporting disputes, and include your documentation. A direct dispute without supporting evidence can be dismissed.

[Your full name]

[Your current street address]

[City, State ZIP]

[Date]

[Furnisher name]

Attn: Credit Reporting Disputes

[Dispute address designated by the company]

Re: Direct dispute of credit reporting — Account [partial account number]

To whom it may concern:

I am disputing information your company is reporting about me to the consumer reporting agencies. I am submitting this dispute directly to you under Section 623(a)(8) of the Fair Credit Reporting Act and its implementing regulation, which require you to investigate, review the information I provide, and respond within thirty days.

Account information:

- Account number: [Partial account number as it appears on your report]
- Account opened: [Date as reported]
- Reported to: [Which bureaus show this item]

What is being reported inaccurately:

[State the specific field and value — for example: "Your company is reporting a date of first delinquency of 06/2021 on this account."]

The accurate information:

[State the correct fact and the evidence — for example: "My records show this account first became delinquent in 11/2019 and was never brought current afterward. The enclosed statements from 09/2019 through 02/2020 document this. The date currently being reported extends the period this account remains on my credit report by approximately eighteen months."]

Enclosed documentation:

- [List each document you are attaching and what it shows.]

I am requesting that your company investigate this dispute, correct the information in your records, and report the correction to every consumer reporting agency to which you have furnished this information. If the information cannot be substantiated, please request that it be deleted.

Please send me written confirmation of the outcome of your investigation and of any corrections submitted to the bureaus.

Sincerely,

[Your signature]

[Your printed name]

[Date of birth] · [Social Security number]

Enclosures: [list]

Sent via certified mail, return receipt requested

LETTER TEMPLATE 5

Debt Validation — Within 30 Days

Send to: a third-party collection agency · Use when: it has been fewer than 30 days since the collector first contacted you

Timing is everything on this one. Sent inside the thirty-day window that opens with the collector's first communication, this requires them to halt collection activity until they mail verification. Outside that window, use Letter 6 instead — sending this one late overstates your position and collectors know it.

[Your full name]

[Your current street address]

[City, State ZIP]

[Date]

[Collection agency name]

[Collection agency address]

Re: Account [reference or account number] · Written dispute and request for validation

To whom it may concern:

Your company contacted me regarding the above account on [date of their first communication]. This letter is sent within thirty days of that communication.

This is not a refusal to pay. It is a written dispute of the debt and a request for validation under Section 809(b) of the Fair Debt Collection Practices Act. I am disputing this debt in its entirety, and I am requesting that you provide verification before any further collection activity occurs.

Please provide the following:

- The amount of the debt you claim I owe.
- The name of the creditor to whom the debt is currently owed, and the name of the original creditor if different.
- An itemization of the debt from the reference date, showing the amount then owed and any interest, fees, payments, or credits applied since.
- The date of the last payment made on the account and the date of first delinquency on the original account.
- Documentation showing your company's authority to collect this debt — whether you own it by assignment or are collecting on behalf of another party.

Under the statute, collection activity must cease until verification is mailed to me.

I am also notifying you that if your company reports this debt to any consumer reporting agency while it remains disputed, it must be reported as disputed.

Finally, I am requesting that all further communication with me regarding this account be in writing, sent to the address above.

Sincerely,

[Your signature]

[Your printed name]

Sent via certified mail, return receipt requested

LETTER TEMPLATE 6

Dispute of a Reported Collection

Send to: a third-party collection agency · Use when: you found the collection on your credit report and the 30-day window has passed

This is the honest version for the situation most people are actually in. The automatic cease-collection right has expired, but you still have the right to dispute, and a collector reporting a debt it cannot substantiate has a reporting problem regardless of the validation window. Send Letter 4's approach to the bureaus in parallel.

[Your full name]

[Your current street address]

[City, State ZIP]

[Date]

[Collection agency name]

[Collection agency address]

Re: Account [reference or account number] · Dispute of reported information

To whom it may concern:

I obtained a copy of my credit report on [date] and found that your company is reporting a collection account in my name. I am disputing the accuracy of that reporting.

The item as reported:

- Reporting as: [Name as it appears on the report]
- Reference number: [As shown]
- Balance reported: [Amount]
- Date of first delinquency reported: [Date]
- Reported to: [Which bureaus]

My basis for disputing:

[State your specific factual basis — for example: "The date of first delinquency shown is 08/2022. The original account with [creditor] first became delinquent in 01/2019, which is documented in the enclosed statement. The date being reported extends the period this item remains on my report beyond what is permitted." Or: "The balance reported has increased by \$[amount] since this account was placed with your company, and I have received no accounting showing the basis for that increase."]

I am requesting that your company:

- Review its records and the documentation enclosed with this letter.

- Correct the inaccurate information with every consumer reporting agency to which it has been furnished, or request deletion if it cannot be substantiated.
- Provide me with an itemization of the amount claimed, showing the balance at the reference date and any interest, fees, payments, or credits applied since.
- Report this account as disputed for as long as this dispute remains unresolved.

I am also requesting that further communication regarding this account be in writing to the address above.

Sincerely,

[Your signature]

[Your printed name]

Enclosures: [list]

Sent via certified mail, return receipt requested

LETTER TEMPLATE 7

Goodwill Adjustment Request

Send to: the original creditor · Use when: an isolated late payment is accurate but the account is otherwise clean

Do not cite statutes in this letter and do not threaten anything. You are asking a person for a discretionary favor, and the moment it reads like a legal demand it gets routed to a department with no authority to grant it. Keep it short, be honest about what happened, and send it to an executive customer service address if you can find one.

[Your full name]

[Your current street address]

[City, State ZIP]

[Date]

[Creditor name]

[Address]

Re: Account ending [last 4] · Request for goodwill adjustment

Dear [Creditor name] team,

I have held this account with you since [year], and other than the period described below, I have paid it on time for the entire relationship. The account is current today and in good standing.

In [month, year] my payment was reported [30 / 60] days late. [Briefly and honestly state the circumstance in one or two sentences — for example: "I was out of work for four months following a layoff in [month] and fell behind on several obligations during that period." Do not over-explain.]

Once I was able to, I brought the account current and I have not missed a payment since. [If true: "I have made [number] consecutive on-time payments since then."]

I am writing to ask whether you would consider a one-time goodwill adjustment and request that the credit bureaus remove the late payment notation from [month, year]. I understand this is entirely at your discretion and that you are under no obligation to do it.

I am asking because [state the concrete reason — for example: "I am applying for a mortgage this year and this single notation is the item standing between my file and the rate I would otherwise qualify for."]

I value this account and intend to keep it open regardless of your decision. Thank you for taking the time to consider the request.

Sincerely,

[Your signature]
[Your printed name]
[Account number]
[Phone number]

LETTER TEMPLATE 8

Removal of Obsolete Information

Send to: the credit bureau · Use when: an item has passed the period it is permitted to be reported

Get the date of first delinquency right before you send this — it is the anchor for the whole calculation, and it is the date furnishers most often report incorrectly. If you believe the reported date is wrong, dispute the date first with Letter 2, then send this once it is corrected.

[Your full name]

[Your current street address]

[City, State ZIP]

[Date]

[Bureau name]

[Bureau dispute address]

Re: Obsolete information — [Your full name], SSN ending [last 4]

To whom it may concern:

My file contains information that has exceeded the period for which it may be reported under Section 605 of the Fair Credit Reporting Act. I am requesting its deletion.

Item:

- Creditor as reported: [Name as it appears]
- Account number as reported: [Partial number]
- Type of item: [Collection / charged-off account / bankruptcy / other]
- Date of first delinquency on the original account: [Date]
- Basis for removal: [For example: "This account first became delinquent in 02/2018. Under the seven-year-plus-180-day period applicable to collections and charged-off accounts, it should have been removed no later than 08/2025."]

[If applicable: "I note that this item no longer appears on my Experian or TransUnion reports, both of which I obtained on [date]. Copies are enclosed."]

[If applicable: "I also note that the date of first delinquency currently shown on your report differs from the date shown by the other bureaus, and from my own records. Moving that date forward is not permitted, and I am asking you to address it as part of this request."]

Please delete this item from my file and send me written confirmation along with an updated copy of my report.

Sincerely,

[Your signature]

[Your printed name]

[Date of birth] · [Social Security number]

Enclosures: [list]

Sent via certified mail, return receipt requested

You Don't Have to Do This Alone

Whatever you decide next, you know more than you did an hour ago.

If you take one thing from this guide, take this: the leverage you have is accuracy, not volume. Find what is genuinely wrong, prove it, and pursue it patiently. Build the positive side while you do it. That combination is what actually moves a file, and it is available to you whether or not you ever hire anyone.

And if you get partway in and realize you would rather have somebody carry it — that is not quitting. That is most people, and it is exactly what we do. We pull and analyze the full profile, work all three bureaus and the furnishers every month, document everything, and guide the rebuilding side alongside it — with a portal so you can see the work instead of wondering about it.

We will also tell you honestly on a first call if your file does not need us. It has happened plenty of times. Either way you will leave that conversation knowing what is actually workable.

First step, whatever you decide

You cannot fix a file you have not read. Pull all three bureaus, save dated copies, and run the audit in Section 4. Everything else in this guide depends on it.

[Get your 3-bureau report](#) · [Free annual reports](#)

Start here — it costs nothing

A free fifteen-minute consultation. Bring your three reports and we will go through them together. No pressure, no contracts, and an honest answer either way.

[Book a Free Consultation](#) · [Start the Done-For-You Service](#)

NextUP Enterprise

Credit Repair · Build Credit · Create Opportunities

support@nextupenterprise.com

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Important Notices

Please read before you act on anything in this guide.

This guide is educational and is not legal advice. NextUP Enterprise is not a law firm and does not provide legal representation. Credit reporting law changes, state law varies, and no outcome is guaranteed — by us or by anyone. If your situation involves litigation, identity theft, bankruptcy, or a debt near your state's statute of limitations, consult a licensed attorney in your state. You always have the right to dispute inaccurate information on your own, for free, directly with the credit bureaus, and to obtain free annual reports at AnnualCreditReport.com. This guide contains referral links to a third-party credit monitoring service; NextUP Enterprise may earn a commission if you enroll through them, at no additional cost to you. © 2026 NextUP Enterprise. All rights reserved.

